Enemies

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/19331860.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora/Catra/Scorpia (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), others mentioned but these are the main ones, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
High Fantasy AU, Arranged Marriage AU, Fluff and Angst, sorcerer!Catra, con artist!Adora, royalty/commoner romance, adora is not raised by shadow weaver, Romantic Drama, Love/Hate, Implied Sexual Content

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by orphan_account

Summary

"You are making a mistake! She's allied with the Horde....."

"I don't give a damn about who's on the Horde's side, any of that political nonsense. You possess the most powerful runestone I've ever seen, but we have no land, no money, and have been basically beggars for your entire life. She is the richest woman in the world, and ruler of the vastest, most prosperous kingdom, needs someone with a runestone to secure her claim to the throne...." Then the words Adora had long been dreading to hear. "You're getting married."

Chapter 1

"Catra, don't go." Adora tugged the shorter girl's hands. "Stay. Stay with me, with us."

Catra pulled away, sparks of fire instinctively brushing from her fingertips. "Adora, I can't keep doing this. Shadow Weaver says things are different in the Horde. Sorcerers are treated with respect, they can train my magic there!"

"The Horde is evil, Catra! Haven't you heard of what they've been doing? Destryoing the earth, torching people who disagree with them? Can't you see...."Adora brushed a lock of her hair out of her eyes. "....we have a good life here?" They were fifteen now, and for the past five years, Adora and her adoptive mother, Freya, had been traveling around with Catra and her guardian, Shadow Weaver. She and Catra had fallen in love as they had gotten older, and now they were dating.

"....by what, being con artists and pickpockets, under the guise of stupid performances and magic tricks? Adora, are you naive to what our life is like?" Adora shrunk back, and struggled to think of a response. She wasn't wrong. Part of their work was magic tricks, singing, dancing, fortune telling, but the real money was made through elaborate cons or petty thievery.

"But I have a runestone now!" Adora gestured towards the turquoise gem on her necklace. Runestones were said to belong to princesses, a mark of power and legitimacy. Even though Adora knew she wasn't a princess, she felt a real connection with her runestone. Before, her magic tricks had just been showy sleights-of-hand, but when she touched her runestone, she felt power flow through her veins, and now she performed real magic. "Who knows what this thing is capable of?"

"Adora, that's probably just a cheap piece of glass. I'm sorry, but I'm leaving. You can come with me or....or stay here."

"You know I can't leave my mom." While her mom wasn't one to speak out openly against the Horde, Adora knew Freya also couldn't stand being tied to one place for very long. And she imagined the Horde probably had harsh punishments for con artists and thieves. "I'm sorry, Catra....."

"Adora!" Freya hugged the young woman. Five years had passed since Catra had left, but despite owning a runestone, not much had changed for Adora. She still traveled with Freya, performing cons and doing magic tricks. "I come with wonderful news. A prospect of marriage!"

Adora bit her lip. "....marriage?"

"Not just with anyone, with Princess Scorpia of the Desert Kingdom." Freya whispered conspiratorially. "She's about your age, rather attractive, kind and patient, not to mention royalty.....she's a perfect match for you."

"You are making a mistake! She's allied with the Horde...."

"I don't give a damn about who's on the Horde's side, any of that political nonsense. You possess the most powerful runestone I've ever seen, but we have no land, no money, and have been basically beggars for your entire life. She is the richest woman in the world, and ruler of the vastest, most prosperous kingdom, but needs someone with a runestone to secure her claim to the throne...." Then the words Adora had long been dreading to hear. "You're getting married."

But I loved Catra.

It was as if Freya could tell what she was thinking.

"Adora, look around you! How many married couples do you see that are genuinely happy? Even the ones who weren't arranged, they're really just with each other because they don't want to be

alone. Romantic love is a lie. This can benefit all of us. You'll have everything you could ever dreamed of, all of our lives would be improved." She touched Adora's runestone necklace. "Adora, your connection with this means you were born for something great. Think of what you could do!"

But is Catra even going to come back?

Maybe marriage wouldn't be all that bad. She'd at least be rich, and maybe she could use those riches for good. Maybe she could even subvert their activities from within and hurt the Horde.

"Fine." She took a sharp breath in. "I'll do it."

"The Princess is here!" Adora couldn't be more nervous as she fiddled with her pleated knee-length dress. She hadn't imagined where she would have met Scorpia for their first meeting, but apparently Princess Scorpia had decided upon a nearby castle to be their first meeting. She gazed out the window, watching almost a parade of horses, jeweled carriages, even a few elephants! Adora had never seen a real one before. Could all of this really be for one person?

"She's traveled weeks to get here to see you!" Freya smiled. "I'm sure it will be love at first sight."

The jeweled carriage door opened, and a few attendants stepped out. When Princess Scorpia stepped out of the carriage, Adora audibly gasped. She still wasn't crazy about the idea of an arranged marriage, especially one with a Horde ally, but Scorpia looked really....pretty? She had a tuft of white-blonde hair, high cheekbones, deep brown almond shaped eyes rimmed with kohl eyeliner, and a cute smile. She was wearing a black formfitting dress with a slit up the side, with crimson jeweled waistband. Adora took in the reality of the situation as Scorpia greeting Queen Angella, who was letting them use her castle. Well, she was probably getting paid for the usage of the castle. Even though they were on opposite sides of the war, a polite cordiality

came between them, although you couldn't miss the body guards surrounding both of them.

Scorpia turned towards her.

"Pleased to meet you, your highness." Adora went into a deep curtsy.

"Pleased to meet you as well, Adora." Scorpia gave a little curtsy back and smiled. "You look lovely in your dress."

"Oh, you look really pretty too."

Scorpia's many ladies in waiting and bodyguards began to fill the castle, followed by animal handlers, and..... *Oh gods, it's Catra. I need to talk to her!* Her heart swelled. Adora waited until Scorpia became occupied by her ladies in waiting, and then went to find Catra. She closely tailed Catra, waiting until she went inside a storeroom, then following her inside..

"Catra, it's me, Adora!"

"Adora...?"

"Catra, I....." *I never stopped loving you.* "...I missed you a lot!"

Catra's expression was one of...sadness? Fear? Definietly not happiness, anyways. "I can't...I can't do this right now."

"Wait, we can talk...." But Catra suddenly snapped her fingers and in a puff of smoke, had completely disappeared. *Well I guess she's been training.*

She became aware of someone else's presence in the doorway.

Scorpia looked close to tears. *Why is she so upset?* "We've traveled two weeks to get here, and within a few hours, you've gotten my best.....my best sorcerer to disappear. What did you even say to her? I knew this was a mistake..."

"Well, marrying someone who willingly allied with the Horde wasn't my first choice either." The words just slipped out.

Scorpia tensed. *Probably shouldn't have said that.* "If you don't know anything, maybe you should keep quiet. Do you think I wanted to practically be forced to get married, either? I'm a competent ruler on my own. I shouldn't have to get married to cement my claim to the throne just because I don't have a connection to my runestone, least of all to someone who knows nothing of government or running a nation."

Adora tightened her hands into balls. "Someone who sided with the Horde is not a competent ruler!"

"You know nothing about my country! The Desert Kingdom is filled with artists, scientists, craftsmen, farmers. We are not, and have never been, a country with a strong military. To resist the Horde would mean sending thousands of civilians to march to their deaths. And more importantly...." She gently tilted Adora's head up so she was looking up into her eyes. "I'm about to be your wife, but I'm also about to be your ruler, and I don't need you to question my decisions, and....."

"Your Highness? It's time to start preparing for the wedding."

"Thank you." Scorpia broke apart from Adora. "We should start getting ready."

"Wait, we're getting married tonight?"

Chapter 2

Adora had pictured her wedding hundreds of times. Always to Catra, even after Catra had left, the fantasy of them reuniting and having a simple wedding always ran through her mind. *But Catra didn't even want to talk to me after not seeing me for five years.* Now she was getting married outside a palace, underneath a thousand stars with hundreds of guests, to someone who wasn't Catra. Adora had changed into a gown with a full tulle skirt, while Scorpia stood opposite her, wearing a dark crimson floor-length dress. They awkwardly rushed through the wedding, the vows, the "I do's".

"I now pronounce you legally married." The officiant declared. "You may kiss to seal this union."

Scorpia leaned forward and gingerly pressed a kiss onto Adora's cheek, close enough that a bystander would mistake it for a kiss on the lips. Their eyes met, and Adora took a sharp breath in. Scorpia gently took her hand and led her through the cheering aisles and inside for their reception.

"Adora, you're shaking." Scorpia gently whispered.

"I'm just....it's a lot to take in, a lot of people watching, I'll be moving halfway across the world...."

"Uhm...do you want a hug?"

Adora nodded, and felt herself being wrapped in a tight, protective, hug. Even though people were all around them, for a second, she could imagine that they didn't exist. They reached the reception hand in hand, to find the ballroom completely decorated with beautiful lanterns from Scorpia's homeland.

"Do you dance? No? It's fine, I'll lead and you just follow." Scorpia led Adora through the first dance. As she whirled and spun Adora around the ballroom, Adora thought to herself, *I really don't*

belong in a world like this. She didn't even know the basics of dancing or court manners, or practically anything about her new wife's homeland. She was just a former con artist who had found a shiny weird stone one day. *But maybe through her, I can subvert the Horde from within, or I can find Catra again.* And it's not like she *disliked* Scorpia. She was attractive, didn't seem to mind that Adora was pretty clueless.....even though she was technically the enemy.

They sat together through the lengthy reception, multiple courses of food, and performers from both their homelands. As the reception carried on, the two managed to get a few seconds alone together on the balcony.

"I know moving to my kingdom will probably be....very different from what you're used to, but I promise it won't be bad. You'll have a lot of free time, you can learn a ton of new things, anything you want, I can buy for you...."

"I'm just....I've only ever kissed one person before, I really don't know anything about relationships, I don't..." She looked at Scorpia's face, earnest and hopeful. "I don't want to disappoint you."

"Adora, we might be technically married now, but I promise, I won't pressure you into anything you're not comfortable with. And you don't....you won't disappoint me. Okay?"

"Okay."

"All right, so you have your own private carriage, but you can sit with me or with your attendants if you feel lonely." The next morning, they were on their way back to Scorpia's kingdom. Adora knew this was technically an arranged marriage, and love wasn't a requirement, but she was surprised by how...open everyone was about it. Her own attendants had been surprised that she had chosen to eat breakfast with Scorpia. This really was all just for

show. Hell, it was practically expected that they would both have lovers on the side.

"Uhm, actually, I was wondering if I could ride one of the horses." Adora pointed at them. She loved horses, but she had never gotten a chance to ride one before.

Scorpia seemed amused by this request. "Sure, you can ride if you want, I'll come with you."

"I think it likes me!" Adora sat happily on top of a pretty grey and white spotted horse as they rode alongside the carriages, and gently patted its mane.

"I just feel you should know that I, I was in love with someone else. Before we met. And I'm still not really over them...." Scorpia looked away shyly.

"Well, we did just meet yesterday, and this is also a purely political marriage, so I'm not hurt or anything." Adora said. "Plus, isn't it the norm for us to have lovers on the side?"

"I mean, we probably are, I'm just sad that she's....she's really gone this time." Scorpia said. *Oh, she wants to talk about her feelings.*

"She was strong, confident, independent, charming....but she always pushed everyone away. I could never really get close to her" *Is she talking about Catra?*

"That sounds like my old girlfriend. Well, ex-girlfriend now, I guess."

"And then you just don't know...."

"...don't know where you went wrong...."

".....and could you ever even fix things?" They finished each other sentences.

I can't believe I'm doing this. Adora sighed as she laid back on Scorpia's bed, Scorpia's arms wrapped around her. They had been on the road for a few days now, and she had found herself coming to Scorpia's tent more and more. They hadn't done anything more than cuddle, but it still made Adora feel surprisingly vulnerable. She had never been held like this before, not even by Catra. *It's just because I'm touch starved. I don't have feelings for her.*

The comfortable silence was broken by a scream, the sounds of glass shattering.

"Oh my God, bandits!" Scorpia practically jumped out of bed.

"Or assassins! You can't go out there!" Adora grasped Scorpia's hand.

"I'm a better fighter than I look." Scorpia grabbed two swords that had been on the side of the tent. "I can't let my people die. If they want me, they can fight me themselves."

"Well, I can't just...." Adora grabbed a third sword. She felt drawn to it, as if by instinct. "Where did you get this....?" She found a small gap in the sword's hilt and without even thinking about it, stuck her runestone into it. She felt her blood pulsing as she grabbed the sword. "I think I just did something with this runestone.....oh." Scorpia had already rushed outside.

"Get away from them!" She swung her sword wildly at a bandit, and surprisingly made a strike! *I may be a former thief, but I never attacked anyone!* It felt like her hands belonged on this sword, with her runestone inside of it. She caught a glimpse of Scorpia, skillfully fighting multiple attackers with her two swords. It was kind of....attractive?

"No one told me my new wife was going to be such a badass." Adora stood back to back with Scorpia, slashing through an attacker with her sword.

For the first time, she felt.....powerful.

It was a quiet night as Adora sat outside alone, thinking. Under the moonlight, a hooded figure approached, halfway across the field. Adora cautiously drew her sword.

"Who's there?"

"Just me." Adora took a sharp breath as the hooded figure revealed herself to be Catra. "Hey, Adora."

"Catra, where have you been?"

"I'm a spy and a sorcerer for the Horde. I needed to do some investigations. Or did you really think I was just some spoiled princesses' sorcerer, only good for party tricks?" Catra scoffed. She grabbed Adora's face. "Aww, and look. The girl who once gave me lectures on morality became the toy of a Horde-allied princess. How far we fall."

"Catra, it's not like that...." Except it kind of was like that.

"So are you a good little pet? Do you come when she calls, and sit when she says sit-"

"Shut up! I hate you so much!" Adora felt herself get closer and closer to Catra. Catra, and her beautiful blue and gold eyes, and that smile, that damned smile. "I hate you, I h-" She and Catra were at each other's throats, and then suddenly their lips were on each others, and they were kissing, kissing harder, Adora's tongue against Catra's teeth.

"Mmmm...." Catra moaned. "You are such a good kisser....."

God, I'm an idiot. Dawn rose, and Adora was curled up in a ball in the grass. After her tryst with Catra, she had begged the other woman to stay, but she had disappeared into the night again.

What had I been thinking? That Catra would stay this time, that things would get better, that they would.....

"Adora?" Adora looked up to find Scorpia. "Are you okay?"

Adora felt terribly guilty and she didn't know why. This was a marriage of convenience, they were going to have affairs with other people, even pretty open ones. Nonetheless, tears still filled her eyes.

"We don't have to talk about it if you don't want to." Scorpia reached over to put a comforting arm around Adora.

"Mom was right. Romantic love is a lie." Adora stared at her shoes.

"I mean, I used to believe that too..." Adora's grey blue eyes met Scorpia's dark brown ones. "I thought I could never get over someone, but then I started to. It's hard but it gets easier."

"Scorpia..." There were a million reasons why she shouldn't feel this way, and a million reasons why she did anyway. "Can you think you love someone, and then also love someone else?"

"You can."

The sky turned a million shades of pale blue, then pink, then yellow as the sun burst across the sky. Adora had her legs wrapped around Scorpia as she gently held her by her waist. Their lips locked, their tongues darting in and out, Adora running a hand through Scorpia's hair. It was like kissing sunshine.

Chapter 3

"So I just wanted to be a superhero and do all sorts of magic stuff....I bet you think that's kind of dumb." Adora ran a hand through her hair as she stood on the marble balcony.

"No, I think it's cute." Scorpia put her hand on top of Adora's. They had reached Scorpia's castle and had been spending the past few days there. While the castle itself was positively opulent, what had surprised Adora the most had been the absolute love and devotion the kingdom's subjects had towards Scorpia. Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed an attendant beckon her inside.

"I'll be right back." Adora's eyes widened as she found the person waiting inside for her. "Freya?"

"Adora, I had been waiting for a good time to tell you this, and I think it's almost time for you to know. Your runestone.....you may think you have some connection to it, but it's not a real runestone."

"This is just, what a cheap piece of glass? We lied to Scorpia like that?"

"It may not be a runestone, but that does not mean it's worthless. It's topaz, your mother's, one of my closest's friends. Her name was Mara, and she was the leader of street performers, petty thieves, con artists, wanderers, beggars.....they all looked up to her. And now, that leadership is passed down to you. These past years, we were never poor, but I needed to train you our ways, and put you into a position where you could lead. Now, you have everything you could dream of, and you're at the center of a massive kingdom."

"I.....this is really my destiny?"Adora felt like she was going to cry. It was just so much to take in.....her, the leader of these people?...the leader even of thieves? Her mother? Her marriage to Scorpia? Did Catra have a part in all of this?

"Adora, I know you can do this....."

"I need to find Scorpia."

Adora felt her heart pounding out of her chest as she entered the hallway. There was Scorpia, happily talking a shorter figure in sorcerer's robes.....was that....it couldn't be....

"Catra, what is going on?" She turned to Scorpia. "And I need to talk to you alone, about something private."

"Let me guess, your runestone isn't a real runestone?" Catra leaned back against the castle wall.

"Okay, we actually have a lot to explain to you." Scorpia glanced around the room. "We should probably move somewhere quieter."

Catra carefully lit a small fire in her hand to light the path down the castle's wine cellar. "So first of all, I do want to apologize for not really talking things out with you earlier. I just wasn't sure if I was being followed, or....." They reached the bottom of the steps. "Adora, when I joined first the Horde, all I wanted was power, but then....I realized that you were right. The Horde was doing evil things, and I didn't want to be part of it anymore, but I was also one of their highest ranking sorcerers....and then I met Scorpia." Catra traced her hand over Scorpia's.

"I'd wanted to go against the Horde for years, but I felt like I couldn't do it without putting my citizens' lives in danger. When I met Catra, we realized that we could use our high ranking positions in the Horde to our advantage, and secretly subvert them from within, smuggle information to the rebellion, things like that..."

"But why stop there? We could choose someone that also could help us expand our spy network, work against the Horde....and of course, I knew you. We did a fake break-up, and then got you two married."

"We'd really love to have your help with this." Scorpia clasped Adora's hand. "Adora, you were born to be the leader of the downtrodden, the forgotten. You could help them, and you could also help everyone by coverty leading them against the Horde."

"I definitely want to help you two, it's just....." *Things are slightly more awkward because I have feelings for both of you now?*

"Everything will work itself out, we promise."

Adora had always dreamed of herself as a hero. Finally, she was one. Just.....slightly unconventional. She skillfully slid down a city roof, wearing a white tunic and black cotton pants, accentuated by a white wrap around her hips that had coins and charms sewn onto it. The common people had taken to calling her "She-Ra", and each day she met with locals, offering assistance, listening to whatever information they might have picked up, paying them to quietly destroy Horde war supplies. When she was done for the day, she discretely made her way back inside the castle.

A sharp knock came onto Scorpia's door. "Your Highness, you have to start getting ready for the social function with the Horde."

"Oh, I really should...." Scorpia made a weak attempt at getting out of her bed, but was playfully pulled back down by Catra.

"Do we really have to go?" Catra nuzzled into Scorpia's neck.

"Yeah, Scorpia, do we have to go?" Adora said from Scorpia's other side. "I know it's an important mission, but I want to stay here together....oh, but we did spend money on new dresses."

"And I got us all some jeweled daggers to hide in our clothes if things start to go south!" Scorpia said cheerfully. "I mean Catra can also incinerate anyone who tries to give us trouble, but I just liked the matching dagger idea."

The knocking started again.

"You know, I think the palace staff has gotten more annoying since they figured out we're all dating each other. It's not my fault, you two are terrible at being subtly romantic." Catra whined.

Adora smiled as she started to get ready. Outside, they all played their different roles. Scorpia, the docile princess. Adora, the "runestone" holder and princess consort. Catra, the dutiful sorcerer. All hiding the fact that they were secretly working against the Horde, as well as their relationship status. Adora's life had definitely turned upside down in the past few months, and she never could have imagined she'd have fallen in love with her two former enemies. *I guess life always has surprises in store for a con artist.* And she couldn't be happier.

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